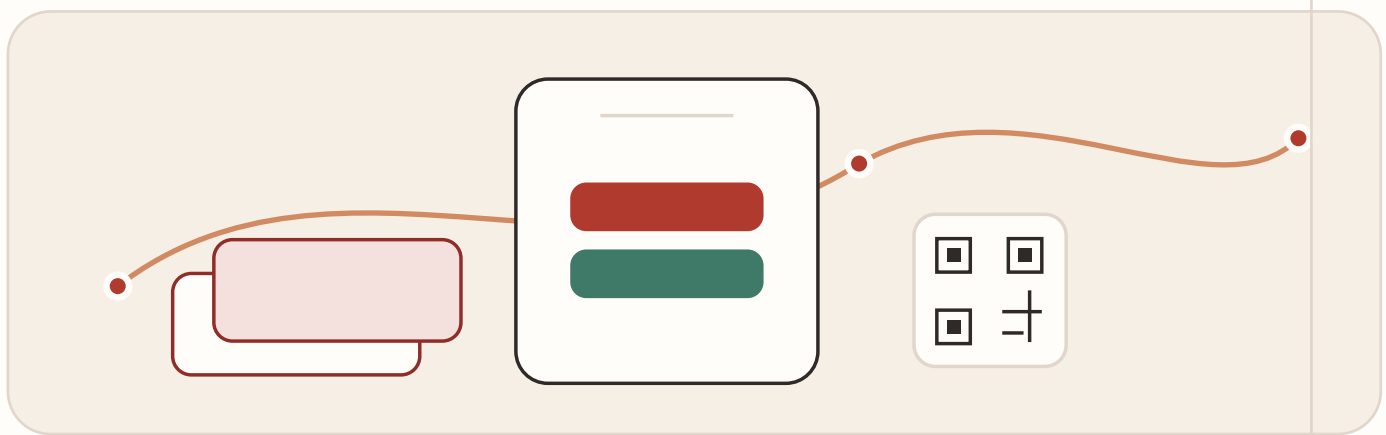


China Payment & Apps Setup Guide

A practical pre-arrival setup guide for Alipay, WeChat Pay, essential apps, and first-day payment backups.



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Use before you fly

Install apps, prepare cards, save addresses, and decide your payment backups before arrival.

Use on arrival day

Run a small payment test before relying on mobile payment for taxis, dinner, or train station snacks.

Use offline

Print or screenshot phrase cards, hotel cards, and the payment backup decision tree.

How to use this guide

This guide is designed to help you prepare before your flight and keep a simple offline backup during your first days in China.

Set up your payment stack Prepare Alipay, WeChat, physical cards, small RMB cash, and a simple fallback order before you need them.	Prepare essential apps Install payment, translation, map, mobile data, and booking support tools while you still have stable internet.
Save backup options Keep hotel addresses, tickets, phrases, and support numbers available offline without saving sensitive passwords.	Print phrase cards Use the Chinese phrases and cards at taxis, hotels, checkouts, and restaurants when translation apps are slow.
Test payment on arrival day Make one small convenience-store purchase before depending on phone payment for transport or dinner.	Avoid first-day confusion Use the decision tree when a card, QR code, network, or app verification step fails.

Best used with	Why it matters
Passport	Hotels, train tickets, some app verification, and ticket checks may depend on passport details.
International bank card	Useful for setup attempts, hotel deposits, larger venues, and backup purchases where accepted.
Phone with roaming or eSIM	Payments, maps, translation, taxis, and tickets depend heavily on mobile data.
Hotel address in Chinese	A reliable offline address can save you if your map, data, or taxi app fails.
Small RMB cash backup	Cash is a practical emergency fallback, even when QR payment is common.

Offline use

Print the checklist and cards, or save the PDF on your phone before departure. Do not store passwords, full card numbers, recovery codes, or one-time verification codes in this document.

Important disclaimer

First China Trip Kit is a practical planning resource for travelers. It is not an official service and it does not guarantee any travel, payment, banking, or immigration outcome.

Always verify official resources before departure

This guide provides travel planning information only. It is not legal, immigration, financial, banking, or official government advice. Payment app support, card acceptance, verification rules, transport policies, and travel requirements may change. Always verify current official information before traveling.

Do not use this guide as	Use this guide as
A guarantee that an app, bank card, visa, route, or merchant payment will work.	A practical pre-trip checklist, worksheet, and offline backup pack.
A replacement for official app notices, bank card rules, immigration rules, or transport policies.	A way to organize what to verify before booking and before relying on payment apps.
A place to store passwords, full card numbers, or sensitive identity details.	A non-sensitive print pack for addresses, support numbers, and simple phrases.

Your pre-arrival setup overview

Use these boxes as your master pre-flight checklist. The goal is not perfection; the goal is to avoid relying on one fragile payment or app setup.

☐	Install Alipay.
☐	Add international card if supported.
☐	Install WeChat.
☐	Prepare translation app.
☐	Prepare map app.
☐	Prepare eSIM or roaming.
☐	Save hotel address in Chinese.
☐	Carry backup cash.
☐	Carry physical bank card.
☐	Test payment on arrival day.

1	2	3	4
Install	Prepare	Save offline	Test
Payment, translation, map, mobile data, and booking support tools.	Passport, cards, bank app, SMS access, hotel address, cash, and phone battery.	Hotel address, tickets, phrase cards, bank support number, and arrival notes.	Make a small convenience-store purchase before relying on apps.

Build your China payment stack

A reliable first-trip setup has layers. Treat mobile payment as important, but keep physical and cash backups ready.

PRIMARY

Alipay with international card
Test with a small purchase after arrival.

BACKUP

WeChat / WeChat Pay if available
Useful for contacts, mini programs, and backup payment.

PHYSICAL BACKUP

Visa / Mastercard
Often useful at hotels, larger venues, and deposits.

EMERGENCY

RMB cash
Keep small notes for taxis, food, and app failure moments.

Do not rely on one payment method only. Prepare a working backup before you fly.

Layer	Use it for	Planning note
Primary: Alipay with international card	Many QR payment situations, some ride-hailing or service flows.	Set up before arrival where possible, then test with a small purchase.
Backup: WeChat / WeChat Pay if available	Messaging, hotel or guide contact, mini programs, and payment backup.	Useful even if payment setup is difficult.
Physical backup: Visa / Mastercard	Hotels, deposits, larger venues, and emergency card use where accepted.	Do not assume every small merchant accepts cards.
Emergency: RMB cash	Taxi backup, small food purchases, app failure, low battery, and no internet situations.	Carry small notes, not a large visible stack.

Alipay setup checklist

Alipay may be the easiest first payment app for many visitors, but setup can still depend on app rules, card issuer support, verification, and merchant flows.

Before setup, prepare	Why it matters	Backup plan
Passport	Identity details may be requested in official in-app flows.	Keep passport accessible; avoid unofficial document upload requests.
International bank card	Card support can depend on issuer, network, country, and app rules.	Try another card, cash, or physical card where accepted.
Phone number	SMS or account verification may depend on a reachable number.	Keep home SIM, roaming, or bank app access ready.
Bank app	Issuer security controls may block or request confirmation.	Check alerts and travel controls if your bank provides them.
Stable internet	Setup and verification are harder on weak airport Wi-Fi.	Use hotel Wi-Fi or mobile data before troubleshooting.
First-day payment test	A small test confirms whether the setup works in real merchant flow.	Do not make taxis or dinner your first test.

Use official app store links

Install from the official iOS App Store or Google Play listing where available.

Follow official in-app verification

Do not send passport or card details to strangers offering shortcuts.

Use matching name format

Where possible, keep passport and card name details consistent.

Test with a small purchase

Try water or a snack before depending on payment for transport or dinner.

WeChat and WeChat Pay backup checklist

WeChat is still useful even if WeChat Pay is not ready. Treat it as communication infrastructure first and payment backup second.

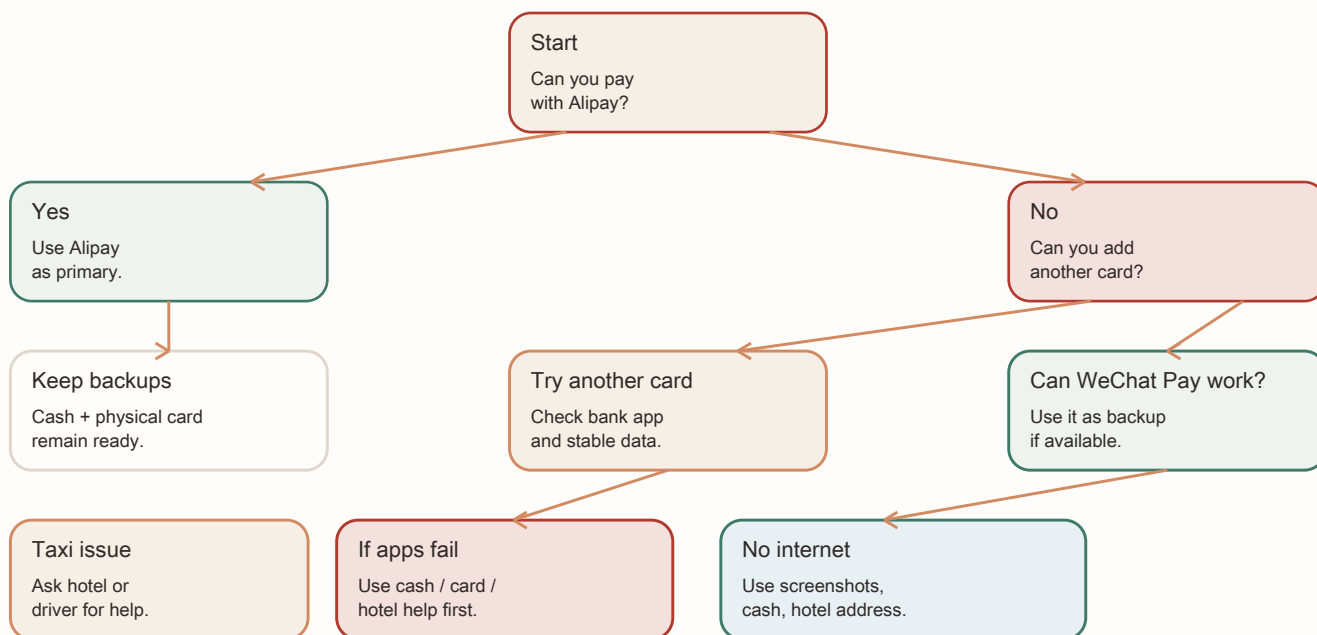
Topic	Useful for	Planning note
Messaging	Hotel, guide, local contact, service desk, or tour communication.	Install before arrival and confirm you can sign in.
WeChat Pay	Payment backup and some restaurant or service flows.	Treat it as backup until you have tested it.
Mini programs	Restaurants, attractions, ride-hailing, and services.	Some flows can be hard without Chinese support.
Setup friction	Foreign card support and verification can vary.	Do not make WeChat Pay your only payment option.
If setup fails	You can still use WeChat for communication if account access works.	Use Alipay first if it works, plus cash and physical card.
When WeChat helps	Hotel communication, local contacts, service counters, QR ordering.	Keep screenshots and translation ready if Chinese screens appear.

If WeChat Pay does not work

Use Alipay as primary if it works. Keep cash, use physical card at hotels and larger venues where accepted, and ask hotel staff for local help when needed.

Payment backup decision tree

When payment fails, move to a working backup first. Troubleshoot later, away from the checkout line, taxi, or station queue.



Rule of thumb

Pay with a working backup first. Debug app, card, or bank issues later, away from a taxi, restaurant line, or checkout counter.

Essential China app stack

Install the must-have tools before arrival. Optional local apps can wait until you understand your data, payment, and translation setup.

App / Tool	Chinese name	Main use	Install before arrival?	Friction	Backup tip
Alipay	支付宝	Payment.	Yes	Medium	Keep cash and card.
WeChat	微信	Messaging + backup payment.	Yes	Medium-High	Use Alipay first.
Translation app	-	Menus and phrases.	Yes	Low	Download offline packs.
Map app	-	Navigation.	Yes	Medium	Save Chinese addresses.
eSIM or roaming app	-	Internet.	Yes	Low-Medium	Save offline screenshots.
Trip.com or train booking support	携程 / Trip.com	Hotels and trains.	Optional	Low-Medium	Save confirmations.
DiDi	滴滴	Ride-hailing.	Optional	Medium	Use inside Alipay if easier.
Amap	高德地图	Local map.	Optional	High	Use with translation.
12306	中国铁路12306	Train info.	Optional	Medium-High	Use Trip.com backup.
Offline screenshot folder	-	Backup.	Yes	Low	Create China Trip album.

First-day payment test

Run one low-stress test near your hotel before depending on mobile payment for taxis, dinner, or station purchases.

1 Choose a low-stress shop Use a convenience store, cafe, or hotel lobby shop near your base.	2 Buy something small Water or a snack keeps the amount low and the pressure low.	3 Test Alipay first Try merchant QR and cashier scan if both are possible.	4 Confirm backup Check card charge, keep receipt if needed, and leave cash ready.
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☐	Go to a convenience store.
☐	Buy water or a small snack.
☐	Open Alipay.
☐	Ask whether to scan or show your QR code.
☐	Confirm card charge.
☐	Save receipt if needed.
☐	Keep cash ready.
☐	Do not depend on taxis or dinner before testing payment.

Test before you are tired, hungry, or far from your hotel.

The best test is a small, boring purchase with no queue pressure. If it fails, step aside and use the decision tree.

Payment troubleshooting table

Use this page when something fails. The aim is to keep moving safely, not to solve every technical issue at the counter.

Problem	Possible reason	What to try	Backup
Card cannot be added	Bank block, unsupported card, name mismatch.	Another card, check bank app, stable Wi-Fi.	Cash or physical card.
SMS verification does not arrive	Roaming off, number format, carrier issue.	Enable roaming, check number format, try Wi-Fi calling.	Try later on stable network.
Merchant says payment failed	QR type, card decline, network issue.	Scan merchant QR, switch card, try WeChat Pay.	Cash or card if accepted.
App asks for identity verification	App compliance requirement.	Follow official in-app steps only.	Do not upload documents through unofficial links.
No internet after landing	eSIM not activated, roaming off, airport Wi-Fi issue.	Activate eSIM, enable roaming, use hotel Wi-Fi.	Offline screenshots + cash.
Taxi cannot accept card	Taxi prefers QR or cash.	Use DiDi or ask hotel.	Cash.
Restaurant only accepts QR payment	Local QR payment preference.	Alipay / WeChat Pay.	Ask if cash is accepted.
Bank blocks transaction	Issuer fraud check or travel rule.	Open bank app or call support later.	Backup card or cash.

Useful payment phrases

Show the Chinese characters if needed. Pinyin is for pronunciation, but the written Chinese is usually more useful in a noisy checkout moment.

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Can I pay with Alipay?	我可以用支付宝支付吗？	Wǒ kěyǐ yòng Zhīfùbǎo zhīfù ma?
Can I pay with WeChat Pay?	可以用微信支付吗？	Kěyǐ yòng Wēixìn zhīfù ma?
Can I pay by card?	可以刷卡吗？	Kěyǐ shuākǎ ma?
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Kěyǐ yòng xiànjīn ma?
The payment failed.	支付失败了。	Zhīfù shībài le.
Could you scan my QR code?	您可以扫我的付款码吗？	Nín kěyǐ sǎo wǒ de fùkuǎn mǎ ma?
Please wait a moment.	请稍等一下。	Qīng shāo děng yíxià.

How to use this page

Show the Chinese characters on your phone. Keep this page available offline in case translation apps or mobile data are not working.

Taxi and hotel phrase cards

These are designed for screenshots or printing. Keep your hotel address card together with these phrases.

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Please help me call a taxi.	请帮我叫一辆出租车。	Qǐng bāng wǒ jiào yí liàng chūzūchē.
This is my hotel address.	这是我的酒店地址。	Zhè shì wǒ de jiǔdiàn dìzhǐ.
Please take me to this address.	请带我去这个地址。	Qǐng dài wǒ qù zhège dìzhǐ.
Can I pay with cash?	可以用现金吗？	Kěyǐ yòng xiànjīn ma?
Please help me contact my hotel.	请帮我联系我的酒店。	Qǐng bāng wǒ liánxì wǒ de jiǔdiàn.

Taxi note

If your destination is difficult to explain, show the Chinese address and hotel phone number. Hotel staff can often help confirm the destination before you leave.

Hotel address card

Hotel address card

Cut out or screenshot this card. Do not write full card numbers, passwords, or bank login details.

Hotel English name	
Hotel Chinese name	
Chinese address	
Hotel phone	
Nearest metro station	
Emergency contact	
Notes	

Use this card

Show this card to taxi drivers, hotel staff, station staff, or airport help desks if your apps fail. Keep the Chinese address visible.

Payment backup card

Payment backup card

Cut out or screenshot this card. Do not write full card numbers, passwords, or bank login details.

Primary payment	
Backup payment	
Cash location	
Physical card	
Bank support number	
Hotel phone	
Emergency contact	
Useful phrase	Can I pay with cash? / 可以用现金吗？

Before you fly checklist

Area	Ready checks
Payment	☐ Alipay installed ☐ International card added if supported ☐ WeChat installed ☐ Cash backup prepared ☐ Physical card packed
Apps	☐ Translation app ready ☐ Map app ready ☐ eSIM / roaming ready ☐ Trip.com or train booking support ready
Offline	☐ Hotel address saved in Chinese ☐ Passport screenshot saved securely ☐ Tickets saved ☐ Emergency phrases saved ☐ Power bank charged

Keep sensitive data out of screenshots

Do not screenshot passwords, recovery codes, full card numbers, or one-time codes. Use offline backups for practical trip information only.

Official resources to verify

Before traveling, verify current information with official or primary sources. Availability may change. Always prepare a backup.

Official or primary source	What to verify
Alipay official resources	Current foreign card support, identity requirements, fees, payment limits, and app notices.
WeChat Pay official resources	Current foreign card support, wallet availability, verification, and usage limits.
China government payment guidance for overseas visitors	Current visitor payment guidance and accepted methods.
Your own bank card issuer	Travel rules, fraud checks, overseas fees, SMS prompts, and card restrictions.
Your hotel or travel provider	Address, payment options, deposit rules, local taxi or arrival help.
Your mobile data or eSIM provider	Activation timing, roaming settings, coverage, and customer support path.

Verified item	Date checked	Note
Alipay card support		
WeChat Pay backup status		
Bank travel controls		
Hotel payment and deposit policy		
Mobile data plan		

Need more China trip help?

Next steps

Visit www.firstchinatripkit.com for city kits, itinerary kits, travel essentials, and free planning tools.

Recommended next page	What to use it for
Start Here	Work through the first-trip preparation sequence.
Best Apps for Traveling in China	Understand your app stack before arrival.
How to Pay in China as a Foreigner	Learn payment scenarios, QR flows, and backup planning.
City Kits	Choose your first China base and save useful Chinese addresses.
Itinerary Kits	Build routes that leave room for jet lag, transfers, and weather.
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Thank you

Thanks for supporting First China Trip Kit. The guide stays practical, cautious, and focused on first-time visitors.